

Talk about Knowing

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I

In this article I wish to suggest a new approach to an old question, the question whether knowing something entails the impossibility of being mistaken about its truth. It will lead to a negative answer to the question, but by a line of argument which will also contain a possible (and I think neglected) explanation why an affirmative answer is so tempting. I shall assume that knowledge is based on evidence, or (to speak more neutrally) restrict myself to such knowledge. The nature and cogency of the evidence is only indirectly my concern; so the term 'conclusive' will be used to indicate neither more nor less than the fact that someone's evidence for p is sufficient evidence for him to know p . What is being asked is whether, if someone has such evidence (and, let us say, infers p) he can *falsely* believe the truth of p . This is not always the same as asking whether p can, still less asking whether it could, be false, for that might be asking merely whether it was contingent. But of course 'it may be false that p ' commonly is equivalent to 'you may be wrong', namely when neither the first is meant as the trivial consequence of "' p " is contingent' nor the second as that of "'you are right" is contingent'.

Certainly it is a necessary truth that if ' p ' is known ' p ' is true; and no doubt some people have confused this with a claim that if ' p ' is known ' p ' is a necessary truth.¹ But I hope to shew that there is more behind the demand for conclusiveness to exclude the possibility of error, and hence for a distinction between knowing and any kind of believing, than that confusion. The reason is that the rules for 'must be' and 'may be' in ordinary discourse do not coincide with those for the necessity and possibility of ordinary modal logic.² That on the contrary they sometimes represent 'epistemic' modalities has of course been claimed by various philosophers (for instance, Frege), and everyone is indebted to Jaakko Hintikka for a systematisation of them.³ In this article the purpose is different. It is to shew how the usage of ordinary discourse does differ from that of modal logic *without* having to represent epistemic modalities. It is that difference, independent of any particular concepts of knowledge, which bears on our question of the relation of conclusive evidence to infallibility.

So as to make the material clear it is presented not as reports of what can be thought about some situation involving or thought to involve knowledge and evidence but as explicit expressions of such thoughts by participants in the situation. To give the simplest of examples, we are going to be presented with conversations in which somebody says that

- 1 A good deal of weight is still put on this confusion: see e.g. the opening of J. Harrison's carefully argued paper, 'If I know, I cannot be wrong', *Proc. Ar. Soc.*, lxxviii (1979), pp. 137-150.
- 2 Cf C. L. Karttunen 'Possible and must', in J. P. Kimball (ed.) *Syntax and Semantics*, vol. 1 (N.Y.: London, 1972).
- 3 See particularly *Knowledge and Belief* (Ithaca, N.Y., 1962).

something is known and somebody else asks how. It would have been possible to have dispensed with direct speech and talked about the situations, even in the case of the more sophisticated interchanges. I mention this only in case the reader might otherwise have been suspicious of the method. It is not that kind of appeal to ordinary language against which someone can object that he would not have said what is being said to be said. All that matters is that the conversations should be possible ones. The task is then to understand them in a way which makes sense of them—makes a coherent interpretation of them, and so reveals genuine or non-contradictory concepts. Whether other conversations would reveal alternative concepts is another question. There are more pressing reasons for preferring direct speech. There are distinctions which depend on tense and person, so that reported speech would anyway have been called for; and one crucial point will depend, as we shall see, on the fact that a sentence is asserted.

II

Jones has pestered Miss Patagonia 1978 on a voyage. But she is a fair-minded woman who knows that some licence is perhaps to be allowed to passengers on a ship. Her uncle, the Patagonian ambassador, is not only fair-minded but a reflecting not to say pedantic man; he believes that for Jones's misbehaviour to be mitigated Jones must not merely have been on a ship at the time but have known that he was on a ship. It is that knowledge which will be in question. A. is the first interchange.

A

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| Miss Patagonia: | Jones knew that he was on a ship. | |
| Ambassador: | How did he know? | |
| Miss P: | He could see waves, he had a steamship ticket to Liverpool, people were behaving like people on a ship, etc. | (E 1) |
| Ambassador: | Even so he might have been on shore. | |
| Miss P: | Yes, but he wasn't. | |
| Ambassador: | How do you know? | |
| Miss P: | I was there . . . , I am now in Liverpool, and I certainly didn't come from Valparaiso in an aeroplane, etc. | (E 2) |

Some preliminary points first. The form in which the evidence for Jones's knowledge and the evidence for Miss Patagonia's knowledge—abbreviated as E1 and E2 respectively—are stated is fairly casual. It is not intended to provoke questions about direct experience and the like. Nothing hangs here on what exactly counts as evidence. On the other hand it must be borne in mind that whoever knows that *p* has evidence that *p*; it may be the case but is irrelevant that there is evidence for every true proposition. The 'etc.' while certainly not intended to indicate some quasi-infinite series which would entail the proposition said to be known, is intended to indicate a true description of the evidence possessed by the person in question and, roughly speaking, a complete one.

The problem we are concerned with at present is the force of 'might have been' in the ambassador's second speech. It would not be natural here, even for a pedant, for it to mean 'even if Jones was on a ship it could have been the case that he was not on a ship because the contrary of every matter of fact is possible.' This would draw attention merely to the fact that 'x is on a ship' represents a type of contingent sentence. The natural interpretation of it is as a concealed argument against the assertion that Jones knew he was on a ship. 'Even so' refers to E₁, and the ambassador is saying that 'Jones was on a ship' could be false and E₁ true. What he is saying implies that E₁ does not entail 'Jones knew that he was on a ship'; and Miss Patagonia puts a natural interpretation on it when she takes the implication to rest on the impropriety of Jones being said to know something which may not have been the case. She could, it may be suggested, have taken the impropriety to consist in his being said to know something on inconclusive evidence. This (as will become clearer) is a different interpretation because 'evidence' in it would refer to evidence possessed by Jones. But she did not need to understand the Ambassador in this way. And she does not. Otherwise she would have said something like 'No he couldn't' or even 'If that's what you think nobody can know anything'. It follows that the 'might have been' (or synonymously 'could have been') is not grammatically counterfactual but merely the past tense of 'may have been'. The ambassador could just as well have said 'For all that (viz. E₁) Jones *may* have been on shore' or 'For all that it may be the case that Jones was on shore'. We have only to imagine him saying to himself 'With the amount they drink it's just as likely they were in a fairground'. There are reasons why the past tense, though equivalent, should be preferred: but they are more linguistic than logical. His argument then is to the effect, 'For all the evidence you have it may be the case that Jones was not on a ship, so you can't say that he knew he was'. *It is not Jones who is at fault (by not having been able to know), according to the argument, but Miss Patagonia for saying he did.* So far as she accepts the 'might have been' it is of course counterfactual. For she produces additional and independent evidence that he was on a ship. Not only does this not mean but it cannot mean that she is trying to remedy the inconclusiveness of E₁ on the assumption that Jones could not have known something unless he had evidence which was conclusive. If that had been the intention the additional evidence, E₂, would not have helped, for it is evidence possessed now by Miss Patagonia, not then by Jones. Notice incidentally that being in the context of, even dependent on, evidence does not make a 'may be' epistemic: it belongs just as much to ordinary logic as the 'some S may be not-P' that is used to contradict somebody who claims that all S is P on the grounds that all M is P and all M is S.

But why should the fact that Jones may not have been on a ship prevent a person from saying (truly) that Jones knew he was on a ship? The explanation is that it is not that fact which would prevent the person but only his acknowledgement of it. *A conjunction of the form 'p but it may be that not p' cannot properly be asserted.* This will include the assertion 'x knew that p but it may be that not p' since 'x knew that p'

implies 'p'. Suppose I am asked for the telephone number of the Patagonian embassy. I might say 'It may be in the directory'. If I then look into the directory I can say 'It is in the directory' or I can say 'It is not in the directory' or I can repeat 'It may be in the directory'; I can also say 'It is not in the directory but it might have been' or 'It is in the directory but it might not have been'. Each utterance would be readily understood. What I cannot say, and mean what I say, is 'It is in the directory but it may not be' or 'It is not in the directory but it may be'. There are only two obvious ways of making sense of the form 'p. it may be that $\sim p$ '—a form, it should be noticed, which is independent of the tense of 'p'. Either (a) what is meant is 'p, but on second thoughts it may be that $\sim p$ ' or (b) what is meant is 'I think that/probably p, but it may be that $\sim p$ '. Either way the form 'p. it may be that $\sim p$ ' will have been surrendered: with (a) we no longer have a logical conjunction which is asserted (i.e. simultaneous assertion), with (b) 'I think that/probably p' is not the same assertion as 'p'.

The linguistic rule, 'a conjunction of the form "p but it may be that $\sim p$ " cannot properly be asserted' has a feature to which I now wish to draw attention. It is a rule about asserting, not about the sentences or sentence forms as such. The meanings of sentences of the forms 'p' and 'it may be that $\sim p$ ' are not such that 'p $\rightarrow$ $\sim$ (it may be that $\sim p$)' is analytic. For what *general* meaning, in terms of inter-sentential implication, can we find for 'it may be' except what is familiar in modal logic either as possibility (Lewis's $\sim \Box \sim$) or contingency ($\sim \Box \sim$, $\sim \Box$)? But with neither interpretation can we have 'p. it may be that $\sim p$ ' as a logical contradiction. To try to do so would be self-defeating since it would be at the price of having 'p', 'it may be that p' and 'it must be that p' all logically equivalent. The upshot is that 'p. it may be that $\sim p$ ' is a so-called paradox of a pragmatic or 'Moorean' kind like 'p. I don't believe that p', not a contradiction. In Hintikka's system (1) 'it may be that p' is interpreted as 'I do not know whether p' and this as 'I do not know that p and I do not know that $\sim p$ ' and (2) sentences whose truth logically could not be known by the speaker are absurd ('epistemically indefensible'). 'p. and it may be that $\sim p$ ' would then obviously be such a sentence. My position here is incompatible with (1): but I see no compelling reason for accepting either (1) or (2).

Now let us suppose a flashback to the scene which took place a few days earlier.

B

- Jones: I know I am on a ship.
 Miss P: How do you know?
 Jones: I can see waves, I have a steamship ticket to Liverpool, people are behaving like people on a ship, etc. (E 1)
 Miss P: You could still be on shore.
 Jones: I could *have* been, but I'm not.
 Miss P: How do you know?
 Jones: As I have already told you, E 1.

Here 'could still be on shore' again means "'E₁' may be true and 'you are on a ship' false. (If Miss Patagonia is herself confident that they are on board she is being captious or else sly, insinuating perhaps 'in the condition you are in'). But 'could have been' must in this case be a rhetorical allusion to the contingency of the fact that he is on a ship—and not necessarily one which is trivially true: one could imagine an unspoken thought of Jones's, 'If you recall, I suggested that we should forget the sailing and go to my apartment'. For B differs from A in the fact that Jones cannot afford to admit that E₁ does not imply that he cannot be mistaken about being aboard, for the admission would imply that his evidence was inconclusive. (It would not be the trivial admission that the proposition is contingent.) Suppose Jones had replied 'Yes, I could still be, but I'm not', Miss Patagonia (if she had had her uncle's logic) would have pounced on this and retorted, 'Then it is only probably true that you are not ashore, and for you to add "but I'm not" is childish because we are interested in what you know not what you are prepared to assert.' In A the admission could be made because further evidence (E₂) could be produced for the truth of what was claimed to be known. This rests on an epistemic difference: E₁ was claimed as Jones's evidence, E₂ was Miss Patagonia's. In B Jones, unlike Miss Patagonia, has already used his evidence (which we agreed should be all the evidence he had). When he says he might have been on shore he cannot mean to agree that for all the evidence he has he may not be on a ship. For that would either have to be interpreted to imply that he had changed his mind about knowing and meant something like 'I haven't got proper grounds but that's what I believe'. This possibility does not interest us because the concept of knowledge would no longer be in question. Alternatively it would have to be interpreted to mean that he was prepared to say 'I am on a ship but I may not be on a ship'. The consequence is that he cannot admit, that is to say assert or be prepared to assert, that the conclusiveness of his evidence is compatible with his being mistaken.

There is therefore a linguistic difference between B and A. What different features in B have brought it about? The claim to knowledge in B is in the first person whereas in A it is in the third person. But it must not be concluded that this accounts for the different treatment of evidence. The following interchange concerns first person knowledge but it is on all fours with A, not B.

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| Jones: | I knew that I was on a ship. |
| Ambassador: | How did you know? |
| Jones: | I could see waves, I had a steamship ticket . . . , etc. |
| Ambassador: | Even so, you might have been on shore. |
| Jones: | Yes, but I wasn't. |
| Ambassador: | How do you know? |
| Jones: | Well, I was in Valparaiso last week, and I'm in Liverpool now, and I certainly didn't come in an aeroplane. |

This was to be expected. From an epistemic point of view Jones is now a different person from what he was, for *his* evidence now does not have to be *his* evidence then.

For the same reason we can get the critical distinction between E₁ and E₂ when we have a present tense claim to knowledge, provided that it is not in the first person.

D

Miss Patagonia: Jones knows that he is on a ship.

Ship's chaplain: How does he know?

E

Jones: You know that you are on a ship.

Miss Patagonia: How do you know?

D and E can obviously continue like A.

In short, there are four grammatical combinations of tenses and persons possible in assertions of knowledge: present or past, first person or other than first person. Of these *only assertions in the present tense and first person exclude the admission by the assertor that even on the assertor's evidence what is asserted to be known may not be/have been the case.*

What has led to this has various implications for the concept of knowledge. Among them these can be noticed now. Evidence for what is known does not have to exclude the possibility of error. For in the first place take the present tense first person cases represented by B, and assume that the hypothesis of possible error does not follow merely from the fact that the proposition known is contingently true. Even there the admission of the possibility does not have to be construed as a contradiction. The reader must decide how much weight to put on this point. But secondly, when the knowledge is reported of someone else the admission is not even a paradox of assertion. There is a further implication that there is a potent reason for the mistaken belief that evidence which is sufficient for knowledge is sufficient to guarantee truth by excluding the possibility of error. This is the special but misleading present tense first person cases, which for understandable but dubious reasons have commonly been considered the standard cases. This potent reason is independent of any confusion between ' $\Box[(\text{it is known that } p) \rightarrow p]$ ' and ' $(\text{it is known that } p) \rightarrow \Box p$ ',¹ and indeed of anything special about turning at all.

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